

Joseph Joachim, who became one of his closest friends and gave him letters of introduction to two of the most distinguished musicians of the day—Franz Liszt in Weimar and Robert Schumann in Düsseldorf.

Brahms and Liszt did not hit it off (Liszt was the supreme keyboard showman, whereas Brahms was reserved in character), but Brahms and Schumann (and his wife, Clara) were kindred spirits: on the day after they met, Schumann recorded in his diary, “Visit from Brahms. A genius.”

Clara was equally enthusiastic: when Brahms played his own compositions, she thought “everything was brimming over with imagination and emotional intensity.” Already, at the age of 20, he was writing music that was remarkable for its rugged strength and pulsating energy, but the Romantic fire was tempered by Classical rigor. Brahms’s work grew more subtle over the years, but this balance between Romantic passion and Classical dignity did not change throughout his career.

Schumann wrote an ecstatic article about Brahms in the music magazine he edited, hailing him as the new messiah of German music, and he arranged for some of his compositions to be published. However, the support of Brahms’s influential champion was cut short by tragic circumstances. Schumann’s mental health had been fragile for some time and in February 1854, after attempting suicide, he was confined to an asylum, where he was to spend the rest of his life. At this time, the Schumanns had six children and Clara was pregnant with a seventh child.

Brahms proved a great support to the distressed family. He was